

J. DEVIKA

GUEST COLUMN

God's Own Cemetery

To survive Kerala of the early 21st century, you need to be adept at navigating the absurd. Friends from Bengal scoff at me when I say this because they have been there, done it. But no. This is a scene worthy of the Dutch Renaissance master Hieronymus Bosch, whose teeming canvases still confound the modern eye. In this ever-growing ocean of fleshly apparitions—which can, without notice, turn into a vast desert, or intimidating voids that can only be imagined—you will encounter some dark ironies. Communist leaders who are said to sup with those given to natural resource predation on a carnivorous scale. Masses of 'empowered' female bodies swaying synchronously or standing in attention at the Supreme Leader's command—witness the semi-feudal Thiruvathira dances at recent CPI(M) district conferences, and the so-called Women's Wall of 2018! Parties committed to liberal democracy that throw out articulate young women members just because they complained of sexual harassment. Also, men of the cloth who specialise in violating nuns or children, as the allegation goes. And megastars who have actually been charged with having their co-stars raped by hired goons—on video—for their own delectation.

They call it God's Own Country, and that is how it might seem to outsiders. But if your eye is the perceptive eye of the imagination, you will see what it is like for insiders: something like Bosch's *Garden of Earthly Delights*—people nearly drowned in a crazy cesspool with a life of its own, periodically stirred by the sneezes of a giant ogre looming over it.

I say 'insiders' deliberately—there are no citizens anymore. Insiders are prey. Judge by the behaviour of the Kerala police. Those who seek protection won't get it—the shadow of Hindutva stormtroopers, or of the Church, falls on them directly. Instead, the police turns on the very human bodies it's supposed to secure. An indigent senior couple already grieving the murder of their 14-year-old daughter had torture in store for them. An eight-year-old girl was given a summary 'public trial' by a Pink Patrol woman cop (the theft charge later turned out to be false). The only one who received a measure of justice is a Swedish tourist accosted around New Year's Eve for possessing two bottles of liquor from the government's alcoholic beverages outlet and not keeping the bill. Outsiders are citizens.

Judge also by the judges. One of them has managed to get his name right into the international press with a bishop's acquittal. The victim, a nun, was deemed less than a "stellar witness" for not being graphic enough. If actors commission rapes for videographic evidence, our judicial system seems to demand near-photographic precision from victim testimonies...almost saying, a la mode, "Pics, or it didn't happen."



Amid intense social change in Kerala, seeds of renewal are sprouting in the form of young women speaking truth to power

As a historian, I have a feeling this is how intense social change might feel at any time, when institutions past their time fight tooth and nail to keep their place. This is how it must have felt in the early 19th century or the early 20th century too. Almost every single institution that emerged out of the last century—the new 'arranged' marriage, the nuclear family committed to child-crafting, the modern caste/ community organisations and modernised religious communities, political parties engaged in community competition for resources, the social development-oriented state—has turned monstrous. But the seeds of renewal are sprouting too. In the form of young women whose struggles have dented all these institutions—Hadiya, who braved family, community, state and Hindutva bullies for her choice of faith and partner; Anupama Chandran, who took on the full might of the CPI(M) to retrieve her baby, kidnapped by her party leader-father in order to protect his 'honour'; Deepa Mohanan, the Dalit scholar who brought the Mahatma Gandhi University to its knees; the brave sorority from the Muslim League women's wing who openly condemned sexual harassers in their party. Maybe the 21st century equivalent of Sree Narayana Guru is born somewhere. Maybe they are womxn or queer. I am hopeful. ■

J. Devika, *historian and social critic, teaches at the Centre for Development Studies, Thiruvananthapuram*

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE